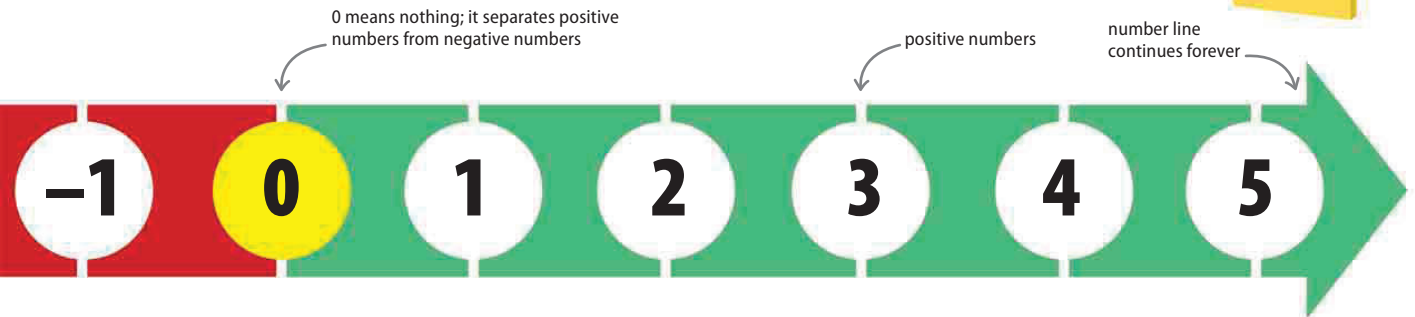


▽ Number line

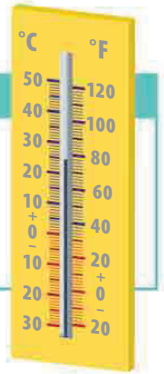
A number line is a good way to get to grips with positive and negative numbers. Draw the positive numbers to the right of 0, and the negative numbers to the left of 0. Adding color makes them easier to tell apart.



REAL WORLD

Thermometer

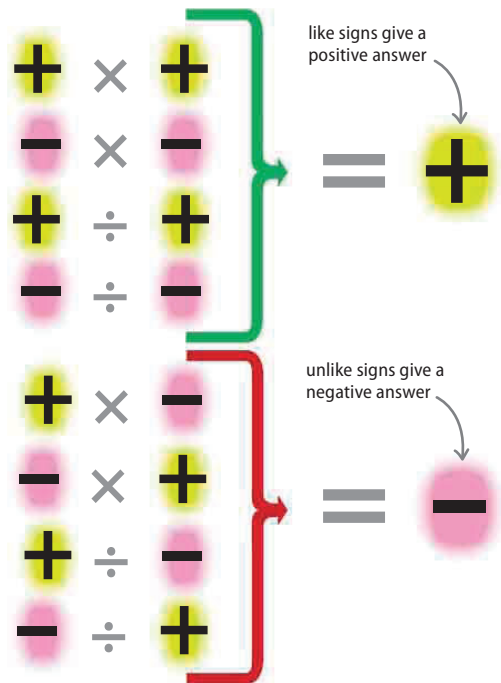
Negative numbers are necessary to record temperatures, as during the winter they can fall well below 32°F (0°C), which is freezing point. The lowest temperature ever recorded is -128.6°F (-89.2°C), in Antarctica.



Multiplying and dividing

To multiply or divide any two numbers, first ignore whether they are positive or negative, then work out if the answer is positive or negative using the diagram on the right.

$$\begin{aligned}
 2 \times 4 &= 8 && \text{8 is positive because } + \times + = + \\
 -1 \times 6 &= -6 && \text{-6 is negative because } - \times + = - \\
 -4 \div 2 &= -2 && \text{-2 is negative because } - \div + = - \\
 -2 \times 4 &= -8 && \text{-8 is negative because } - \times + = - \\
 -2 \times -4 &= 8 && \text{8 is positive because } - \times - = + \\
 -10 \div -2 &= 5 && \text{5 is positive because } - \div - = +
 \end{aligned}$$



△ Positive or negative answer

The sign in the answer depends on whether the signs of the values are alike or not.